

and technologies that are revolutionising industries and reshaping markets in sectors like e-commerce, SaaS, energy, healthcare, life sciences and telecom, along with a host of emerging themes from AI to spacetech, etc.

Recognising early on the vital role technology will play in India's future, Prime Minister Narendra Modi put India on the path to become a 'Digital Nation' in 2015. It unleashed a massive effort to deploy high-speed networks across the country's remote, rural regions and urban areas, connecting over 800 million people via their mobile phones. Today, the rapid spread of digital connectivity and smartphones is enabling half a billion Indians to leverage the digital ecosystem to make their everyday life more productive and financially rewarding.

Under PM Modi's leadership, India has led the world in creating a replicable digital public infrastructure with population-scale APIs and a home-grown "India Stack" to connect its 1.4 billion people. Using the Aadhaar number and a set of APIs, the country has connected governments, businesses, start-ups, developers and users to do everything from pay taxes and book railway tickets to apply for passports and access scores of day-to-day services. This has improved efficiency, transparency and reduced corruption. A prime example is the real-time payments network Unified Payments Interface (UPI) that has clocked the highest number of digital payment transactions in the world since its launch in 2016.

The fault lines exposed by Covid-19 has alerted nations around the world to diversify their supply chains and seek trusted partners, and avoid disruptions to their industries during times of war and geopolitical uncertainties. This has created a golden opportunity for India to become a hub for the world's high technology and innovation needs. Consequently, India recently unveiled incentives worth tens of billions of dollars to create an ecosystem for electronics systems and semiconductor manufacturing in the country. India, with its great track record of respecting and protecting intellectual property and its large talent pool, is being actively looked upon by the West as a trusted partner. Apple's recent plan to produce its latest iPhones in India is a prime example.

Further, the spread of internet at the turn of the century brought India Inc.'s skills and talents in the IT

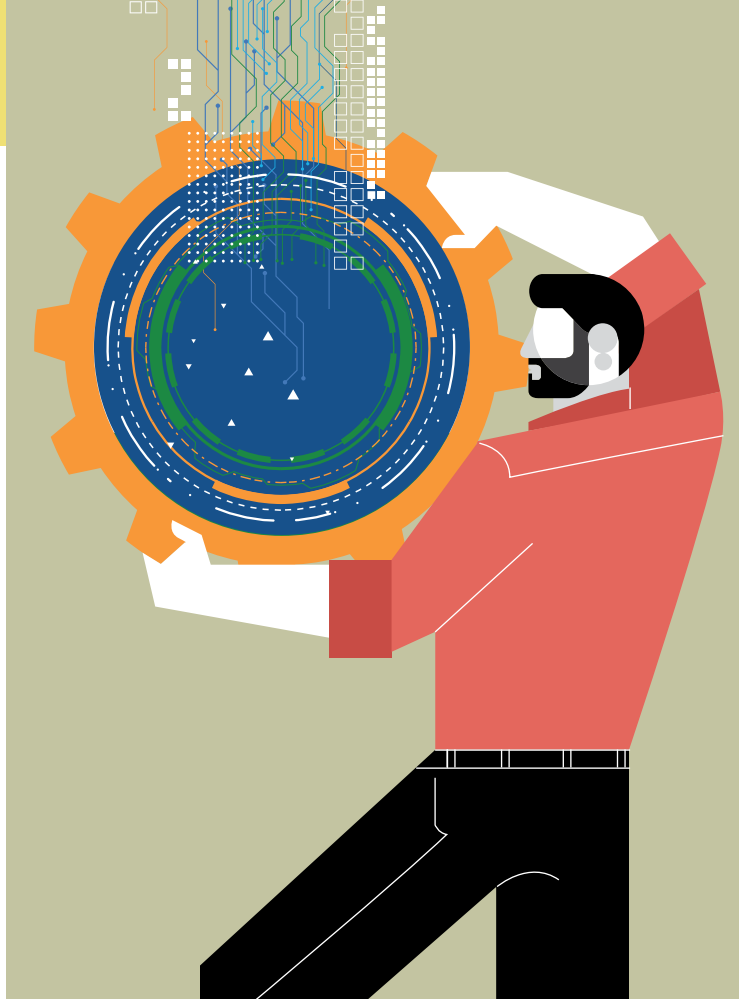


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and software space to the fore. Now, it is building on its core tech-savviness to become a thriving centre of innovation in semiconductors, AI, cybersecurity and quantum computing technologies, among other emerging technologies. And today, India has the fastest-growing entrepreneurial ecosystem in the world. Further, the fact that Indian-origin talents lead some of the largest tech companies of the world today is a testimony to the growing clout of India's tech talent.

India is rapidly transforming into a decisive, far-sighted and strong nation under the astute leadership of PM Modi. After decades of diffidence, it is ready to play a more prominent role in the new global order emerging in the wake of the Covid-19 pandemic and the Russia-Ukraine conflict. Relying on my experience with technology, I can say that an exponential change starts gradually, then accelerates suddenly. India is on the verge of just such a transformation. By deepening its global footprint and asserting its commitment towards a just world that is collaborative, equitable, and one that democratises opportunity for shared peace and prosperity, India is marching forward to claim its rightful place on the world stage. **BT**

Views are personal